first brought for collective immersion in the 16th century lake—calling it a "matter of faith". On its part, the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation (GHMC) has made elaborate alternative arrangements, spending over Rs 5 crore for PoP idols to be immersed in makeshift ponds this year. Besides 24 fibreglass prefabricated ponds brought from Mumbai, it has created 50 artificial ponds across the city where idols taller than six feet can be immersed. This raises the number of immersion locations from just 28 last year to 74, and was thought sufficient to ease the strain on Hussain Sagar.

The lake was to go off-limits for immersion last year, but the ban was deferred when the Supreme Court accepted the GHMC's petition and, staying the September 2021 order of the Telangana High Court, gave the authorities "one last chance". A three-judge bench led by Chief Justice N.V. Ramana had passed that order based on the state government's undertaking that there would be no immersion of PoP idols from 2022. But the BGUS is having none of it, and is keen on immersing most idols in Hussain Sagar at the end of a massive procession—partly to make up for two years of low-key festivities owing to the pandemic, and doubtless also to keep emotions around religion at an elevated level ahead of a crucial bypoll in Munugode. "The high court has allowed PoP idols. Making arrangements for immersion is the government's responsibility," says BGUS general secretary Bhagwant Rao Pawar. Thus, from an ecological question of protecting lakes and water bodies, it has turned into a political hot potato. The TRS is apprehensive about the BJP using the occasion to stoke communal passions. The police have told pandal organisers to declare whether they are installing PoP or clay idols to assign them immersion points accordingly. Hopefully, tempers will stay cool through this attempt to bring about a significant and salutary shift in a mass ritual—if the surrounding rituals of politics allow it.■



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BLACK DAY Protesters hold a black flag against the bail granted to the BJP's Goshamahal MLA, T. Raja Singh (above). The party suspended him after his derogatory remarks on the Prophet, but social media was awash with threats



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By Prashant Srivastava

In politics as in art, a lot of effort goes into making something look effortless. The BJP's runaway victory in the assembly election early this year may have deluded the casual observer into thinking 2024 would be a cinch—that a saffronwash over Uttar Pradesh's 80 Lok Sabha seats was a fait accompli—but party strategists know nothing is inevitable. For one, the BJP's chief rival, Akhilesh Yadav's Samajwadi Party, had paradoxically had its best outing ever in terms of votes and vote share—7.5 million more than its 2012 win, and a robust 32.06 per cent. To stay ahead, the BJP just has to get its engineering right, both at the top and in terms of its social base. If, uncharacteristically, a shadow of conflict was visible over the first, the second still had gaps.

Last week's organisational reshuffle—with Bhupendra Singh Chaudhary coming in as the state president and Dharampal Singh as general secretary (organisation)—sought to address both needs at once. The two new helmsmen are from western UP, so their conscription is aimed at striking a regional balance, given that both Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and